



Navigating social and emotional learning evidence in a polarized socio-political environment: A qualitative pilot study of SEL stakeholders[☆]

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ABSTRACT

An increasingly polarized socio-political climate is diminishing the public's confidence in the SEL research evidence. In some cases, producing misinformation – or false evidence- as well as disinformation – or intentionally false evidence. Both have the potential to contribute to exclusionary policies and inequitable social and emotional experiences for students in the United States. This manuscript explores whether and how SEL stakeholders ($n = 25$) understand, access, and use evidence to inform SEL-related decisions across professions, including K-12 educators, school administrators, and district personnel as well as policymakers, parents, and SEL researchers and advocates. Results from this pilot study suggest that SEL research evidence currently lacks accessibility for policymakers, educational leaders, and practitioners, and that the evidence that is available is limited in how it can be translated to and used in practice. How stakeholders identify and use SEL evidence is diverse, and most stakeholders access SEL evidence via news and education media. Opportunities for improving SEL evidence understanding, access, and use in the current U.S. socio-political climate are discussed.

Impact statement: Findings suggest that SEL misinformation is likely more accessible to decision makers than the evidence that illustrates the success and benefits of SEL programming. Without continued proof and confirmation about what SEL is and how SEL is benefiting the nation's youth, false narrative surrounding SEL that is being advocated for by specific groups and politicians is likely to prevail, resulting in continued skepticism about the use of SEL approaches in classrooms. This policy analyses and research study yield significant implications for SEL researchers and other stakeholders interested in creating, disseminating, and using SEL research in practice.

Supporting the academic, social, and emotional health of youth in the United States demands urgent intervention. Since the COVID-19 pandemic interrupted learning, teaching, and thriving nationwide, young people in the United States have reported high rates of hopelessness, depression, and suicidality (CDC, 2024a; 2024b) concurrent with record low rates of academic achievement (National Center for Education Statistics, 2022). Although by no means a panacea for these interconnected challenges, evidence-based social and emotional learning (SEL) approaches in schools that explicitly support cognitive,

ffective, social, and behavioral skill-building is one approach to address the declining social, emotional, mental, and academic health of students across the country. Despite the robust research evidence for SEL, public confidence in this evidence appears to be waning, influenced in part by an increasingly polarized socio-political climate. This environment has also contributed to the spread of misinformation – or false evidence- as well as disinformation – or intentionally false evidence. Both have the potential to contribute to exclusionary policies and inequitable social and emotional experiences for students in the United States.

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Improving the conditions for student learning and thriving requires intentional and preventative action that explicitly addresses mis- and disinformation and communicates rigorous and relevant research evidence to all stakeholders. Stakeholders include those who engage with and use SEL in their professions, including educational leaders (e.g., superintendents, chancellors, commissioners, and principals), educational practitioners (e.g., teachers, school counselors, school psychologists), SEL researchers, and policy advocates, as well as policymakers and parents. Developing the political will for investments in SEL demands the effective dissemination and communication of rigorous evidence that demonstrates the benefits of SEL programs on youth well-being and academic success (Steigman & Belledonne, 2024). The purpose of this manuscript is to explore whether and how SEL stakeholders interact with evidence to inform SEL-related decisions. First, we describe the current challenges to SEL evidence dissemination and the state of the evidence for SEL in the United States. Next, we detail a pilot study of SEL stakeholders' understanding, access, and use of evidence to inform their SEL-related decision-making. We conclude with a discussion of the barriers to and opportunities for improving SEL evidence understanding, access, and use in the current U.S. socio-political climate.

Partisanship, misconceptions, and disinformation

Over the past three decades, SEL skyrocketed to the forefront of American educational discourse, now prominent in federal, state, and local policy, across K-12 education, and in many households nationwide (Shriver et al., 2024; Skoog-Hoffman et al., 2024; Steele et al., 2024; Yoder & Dang, 2023). All 50 states have established pre-K standards (CASEL, n.d.), and 27 states have adopted SEL standards spanning pre-K through grade 12, with an additional 17 states including SEL standards from pre-K to age 5 (Stanford & Meisner, 2023). Additionally, Vermont and Connecticut have SEL benchmarks for pre-K through third grade (Stanford & Meisner, 2023). This broad adoption across both liberal- and conservative-leaning states illustrates that SEL is not confined to a select group but reflects broad, bipartisan engagement across the country (see Yoder et al., 2020 from CASEL emerging insights and Dermody & Dusenbury, 2022 for the latest state scan of SEL standards).

SEL's growing presence in America's educational system (e.g., state standards and school-based interventions) has also thrust the science of learning and social and emotional development into partisan discourse. Attention to SEL at the national and municipal levels increased significantly over the past three years, with bipartisan resolutions introduced in the U.S. Senate in 2023 and 2024 establishing a "National Social and Emotional Learning Week" (S. Res. 105, 2023; S. Res. 576, 2024). During this designated week, lawmakers, practitioners, researchers, parents, students, schools, and other stakeholders underscore the critical role of SEL in promoting students' academic success, mental health, and long-term well-being (Durbin, 2025; S. Res. 107, 2025). SEL week also coincides with International SEL Day, which is an initiative that promotes evidence-based SEL practices across schools and communities worldwide (see www.selday.org). Both efforts seek to raise awareness of SEL's importance in fostering supportive learning environments for students across the international community.

Concurrently, the 2025 *Labor, Health and Human Services, and Education, and Related Agencies Appropriations Act* called for the "Department [of Education] to continue prioritizing and funding quality applications for eligible social and emotional learning projects" (S. Rep. No. 118–207, 2024). SEL also has nonpartisan support among parents across the country. Nearly 90 % of the more than 2500 K-12 parents surveyed by the National Parent Teacher Association (PTA) were comfortable with their children learning social skills, including empathy, in school, and over 75 % supported SEL overall (National Parent Teacher Association, 2022). Likewise, McGraw Hill (2021) surveyed 205 parents and found that 81 % believe SEL is not utilized enough. In a survey of over 3000 parents of K-12 children, the Pew Research Center examined SEL

support across the political spectrum and found that nearly all (93 %) parents, democrat, democrat leaning, republican, or republican leaning, believe it is very/extremely or somewhat important that their children develop social and emotional skills during school (Horowitz, 2022). Similar sentiments are also expressed by educators. McGraw Hill (2021) surveyed more than 300 teachers and found that 90 % believe SEL can reduce bullying, increase student engagement, improve school safety, and strengthen student-teacher relationships.

Despite bipartisan support for teaching social and emotional skills in schools, Congress has been a house divided on investing in SEL. Many members of the Democratic party have supported an SEL initiative that funds \$87 million toward "evidence-based, field-initiated grants that address student social, emotional, and cognitive needs" while members of the Republican party have proposed an "elimination" of the initiative (House Appropriations Committee Democrats, 2023; 2024). At the state level, National Public Radio (NPR) found that debates and disagreements about SEL have emerged in half of U.S. states (Anderson, 2022), with eight states proposing legislation to eliminate SEL in K-12 classrooms (Abrams, 2023). None of these proposed bills had passed at the time this manuscript was prepared, although alternative legislation that takes a broader approach to limiting SEL in schools is beginning to gain traction.

Contemporary SEL political discourse

The partisan discourse around SEL is largely driven by party-level politics and contains a range of actors across the political spectrum. In this section, we detail key leaders and events in contemporary SEL political discourse.

From the Right. The skepticism of SEL from the right of the political spectrum (i.e., Republicans) is largely rooted in the misappropriation of SEL as indoctrination, the assertion that SEL in schools is a "Trojan Horse" that deceptively pushes specific ideas and concepts, such as those outlined in Critical Race Theory (CRT; Anderson, 2022; Hytrek, 2023). In House Appropriations subcommittee testimony on SEL and Whole Child Approaches in K-12 Education, Max Eden, a senior fellow at the American Enterprise Institute, conservative leaning think tank, argued that current operationalizations of SEL in schools extends beyond the Collaborative for Academic, Social, and Emotional Learning (CASEL)'s original definition of SEL to now include promotion of ideological and political ideas related to race, gender, and uncovering trauma (Eden, 2023; *Social and Emotional Learning and Whole Child Approaches in K-12 Education*, 2022). Chris Rufo, a conservative activist and leader of anti-CRT legislation across the country, spread significant disinformation about approaches to SEL in schools, referring to SEL as a delivery mechanism for CRT and racial pedagogies. Rufo incorrectly describes SEL as an attempt to "soften children" and to "rewire [their] behavior according to the dictates of left-wing ideology" (Goldstein & Saul, 2023). Influential political organizations, namely Moms for Liberty, a parents' rights organization that advocates against inclusive topics in school curricula⁷—strategically message this SEL disinformation as falling under parents' rights in education. The parent guides and resources developed by Moms for Liberty use this SEL disinformation to garner parental support for banning SEL approaches in schools by making unsubstantiated claims that SEL indoctrinates children, promotes "Marxist" ideology, and harms students (Moms for Liberty, n.d., p. 9).

Organized groups of parents have a growing role in federal, state, and local decision-making about the presence of SEL in schools with clear evidence of success (see parent support for anti-SEL Iowa Senate Bill 85 in Hytrek, 2023). The Brookings Institution found that Moms for Liberty chapters are active across right leaning, left leaning, and swing

⁷ Sample topics include LGBTQ rights, race and ethnicity, restorative justice, CRT, and gender ideology.

states, with the second largest membership found in left-leaning New York and the third largest membership in the swing state of Pennsylvania (Sinha et al., 2023). In fact, in school board races, winning candidates endorsed by Moms for Liberty tended to be from swing and suburban counties (Sinha et al., 2023). The Moms for Liberty success with voters that are needed to win state and nation-wide elections (i.e., swing and suburban voters) has influenced high-profile politicians to consider the Moms for Liberty platform. During the 2024 election cycle, Moms for Liberty held a summit that many prominent politicians and presidential candidates attended, where some linked SEL to “liberal indoctrination” or “woke ideology” (Stanford, 2023). As voters respond favorably to such disinformation around SEL, the large body of evidence on SEL effectiveness from the research literature is being overlooked and undermined (Cipriano et al., 2023; Strambler, 2023; Strambler et al., 2024).

This messaging has further fueled state-level legislation that seeks to ban or reduce SEL in schools. In North Dakota, House Bill 1526, which failed to pass, restricted how teachers interact emotionally with their students, and highlighted the role of the family in engaging in emotion-focused discourse (North Dakota House Bill 1526, 2023). The sponsor of this bill suggested that SEL is no longer what it is marketed to be and argues that SEL “has characteristics of a destructive weed” and “is indoctrination, not education” (Hoverson, 2023). In Oklahoma, failed Senate Bill 1027 sought to outright ban SEL in schools, noting that parents have the right to file a report with their county’s district attorney if they believe their school violated the anti-SEL policy outlined in this bill (Oklahoma Senate Bill, 1027, 2023). The sponsor of the bill asserted that,

The SEL platform sounds admirable, with goals of addressing the social and emotional development needs of children, but the motives of these programs are actually much more sinister...SEL’s actual objective is to condition children to prescribed behaviors and ‘anti-racist’ training, social justice posturing and the sexualization of minors, all under the guise of affirming feelings. SEL seeks to find ‘traumas’ in our children as a pretext to push anti-family, anti-logic and anti-reason philosophies and leftist political ideologies (Oklahoma Senate, 2022).

The Arizona Department of Education dedicates an entire webpage to linking CRT and SEL, stating, “SEL is a gateway method – a ‘Trojan Horse’ - to introduce the elements of CRT into the schools” (Arizona Department of Education, 2025a). The website states that SEL leads schools to “indoctrinate children” and argues that using SEL “as part of the regular curriculum...is wrong for a number of reasons” (Arizona Department of Education, 2025a). The Arizona Superintendent of Public Instruction has also asserted that CRT “is taught under different titles” which include “social and emotional learning” (Arizona Department of Education, 2025b). Finally, a failed house bill in Maine incorrectly identified CRT, SEL, and DEI as the same instructional approaches (Maine House Bill 618, 2023). Although it is unclear whether SEL research evidence was used to make such claims, and whether a content analysis of SEL curricula was conducted across each of their respective states. What is clear, however, is that each of these states had SEL standards and guidelines at one point in time (Yoder et al., 2020).

From the Left. Criticism of SEL approaches in schools has also emerged from progressives and the political left (i.e., Democrats) (Strambler, 2025; Strambler, 2023). Strambler (2023) suggests there are three common assertions from this side of the political spectrum: Without considering critical social justice (1) SEL is ineffective for marginalized students; (2) SEL acts to support white supremacy and harm marginalized students; and (3) SEL and critical social justice enhance each other’s goals. Early and emerging research in this area exploring empirical outcome data suggests that this may not be the case (Strambler et al., 2024). However, there is evidence that current pre-K-5 SEL programming rarely “address issues of racial justice, identity, power, privilege, bias, and oppression” (Ramirez et al., 2021, p. 12).

Three recent systematic reviews on culturally responsive, evidence-based SEL programming each found fewer than 20 studies that mentioned programs with a cultural component or adaptation (Li et al., 2024; Lim et al., 2024; Heidelberg et al., 2024). Findings across these studies also indicate mixed student outcomes (Heidelberg et al., 2024; Li et al., 2024; Lim et al., 2024). Research explicitly validating the impacts of SEL for students at the intersection of their racial and ethnic identities, as well as exploring the role that cultural adaptations to SEL can play in strengthening these effects, is therefore an important area for future research.

From the Field. In the SEL field, there are ideological differences of what SEL programming should entail where one faction is organized around SEL programming that is grounded in antiracism and supporting justice-oriented actions in schools while the other focuses primarily on explicit SEL skill-building. Cipriano and Strambler (2024) explain that justice-oriented approaches to SEL, including transformative SEL (Jagers et al., 2019), are distinct from skills-based approaches to SEL, and the field needs to be more specific in differentiating between SEL approaches, the skills taught, and the outcomes intended, in the service of true transparency. They warn that the ideological rhetoric that is emerging from such divisions is likely to have significant political implications for the SEL field within the current socio-political climate, especially in the absence of empirical evidence.

These field debates are unfolding alongside growing federal involvement, which has further politicized SEL through formal policy responses and regulatory guidance aimed at restricting its use. Three weeks into the second Trump Administration, the Department of Education, Office of Civil Rights (2025a) issued a mandate, now largely known as the “Dear Colleague” letter that has sought to deter schools and states from implementing SEL. The letter makes clear that federally funded schools and colleges cannot use race as a factor in their programs or policies, even when those actions are intended to promote diversity, equity, or inclusion. The follow up to the letter, *Frequently Asked Questions About Racial Preferences and Stereotypes Under Title VI of the Civil Rights Act*, notes SEL can “veil racially discriminatory policies” (Department of Education, Office of Civil Rights, 2025b, p. 6). This federal push to restrict SEL stands in stark contrast to the strong support for SEL at the local and state levels. Skoog-Hoffman et al. (2024) found that more than 80 % of K-12 principals say SEL is implemented in their schools and “[a]ll but one of 50 states (plus DC) have at least one supportive policy or condition to support SEL implementation” (pp. 7, 12–13). Given how widely SEL is implemented, such federal actions introduce significant uncertainty and potential risk for schools navigating these mandates. Additionally, despite the robust research evidence for SEL supporting all students with skills vital to their success within and outside of school, the Dear Colleague letter contributes to diminishing public confidence in SEL by suggesting that it could be unlawful, ultimately undermining the evidence base that supports its continued use.

What’s in the name? Public opinion polling suggests that the problem with SEL may lie in its name. The Fordham Institute, along with YouGov, asked 2000 parents to identify up to three phrases among a list of 12 (e.g., 21st century skills, whole child development) associated with programs that “could relate to aspects of child development beyond academic skills” that they would “least want” their “child enrolled in” (Tyner, 2021, p. 38). They found that most parents reacted favorably to the phrase “life skills,” while “social and emotional learning” ranked 11th out of the 12 SEL-related terms and phrases (last was “soft skills”) (Tyner, 2021, p. 7). The survey also found that parents overwhelmingly supported SEL skills when asked about them individually (e.g., goal setting, facing challenges with optimism; Tyner, 2021, p. 5). Parent support for programs focusing on life skills but not SEL, suggests that anti-SEL messaging may be succeeding. When examining state initiatives (e.g., resilience programming in Florida) and laws, it appears that state leaders are aware that their key constituents support SEL competencies for youth, but not the term associated with it. This is exemplified

in another state (masked) where the state promotes “life skills” which encompasses “self-awareness, self-management, responsible decision making, relationship skills, and social awareness” (i.e., CASEL’s five core SEL competencies).

In some cases, SEL opponents are advocating for practices that are nearly identical to skills-based SEL but refer to them by a different name. First Lady of Florida, Casey DeSantis, announced an investment of 21 million dollars in the Florida school system to develop and implement resilience programming (Executive Office of Governor Ron DeSantis, 2023). The newly adopted standards “incorporate key resiliency skills, including grit, perseverance, gratitude, personal responsibility, volunteerism, critical thinking, problem-solving, empathy, citizenship and honesty” (Executive Office of Governor Ron DeSantis, 2023, n.p.). The new resiliency program encompasses SEL skills and competencies, but under a different name. This is not unusual. Terms including 21st century skills (Vivekanandan, 2019), durable skills (Pelosse, 2022), life skills (State and House Bill number masked, 2025), and employability skills (Committee for Children, 2016) are all clusters of SEL skills and competencies by a different name.

Importance of understanding how SEL evidence is accessed and used

Scattered within the sea of SEL disinformation, misinformation, and messaging are pockets of examples that demonstrate how SEL evidence has been vital to reducing partisanship and combating political misinformation and misconceptions in action. In a public hearing in February 2023 for the Montana’s House Education Committee regarding House Bill 688, which sought to ban SEL instruction in schools and teacher training of SEL, various SEL stakeholders, including educators and parents, expressed opposition to the bill and provided testimony in support of SEL programming (Montana House Education Committee, 2023; Stanford & Meisner, 2023). The discussion ended with the sponsor withdrawing the bill and concluding, “I did not have a clear vision of [SEL], as I was just trying to have a discussion on what people have been asking me for a long time—what is social-emotional learning? So, you have taught me well” (Stanford & Meisner, 2023, n.p.). Importantly, much of the data presented during this hearing was anecdotal in nature, which leads to the question of what types of SEL evidence stakeholders access and use in their professions.

For research to be used, it requires more than producing and disseminating evidence through typical channels such as scientific journals. There are four main problems with this approach. First, it is estimated that half of all journal articles are never read by anyone beyond the authors and the journal staff and reviewers, which suggests these articles have a limited audience (Eveleth, 2014). Second, when research does make it to the public eye, it is vulnerable to being - albeit unintentionally or intentionally - misunderstood and misrepresented (e.g., to fit certain political narratives). Third, this model facilitates a disconnect between researchers and practitioners, who may not traditionally interact with, read or have access to academic journals. Finally, most journal articles are behind paywalls, making them inaccessible to individuals without university affiliations or institutional subscriptions. While individual journal issues or articles are sometimes available for purchase, they are typically sold at a high cost, which further limits the reach and impact of scholarly research.

Current study

Amid a cacophony of political discourse, mis- and disinformation, it remains largely unknown whether and how SEL research evidence is interpreted, communicated, and used across decisionmakers in the education ecosystem, including educational leaders (e.g., superintendents, chancellors, commissioners, and principals), practitioners (e.g., teachers, school counsellors, school psychologists), researchers and policy advocates as well as policymakers and parents. This exploratory pilot study seeks to (a) fill this knowledge gap by exploring whether and how multiple stakeholder groups use SEL research evidence and (b) help

chart the path forward for navigating SEL in the current socio-political climate.

Methods

This study used a constructivist grounded theory approach to data collection and analysis. A constructivist approach requires us to examine the mechanisms through which SEL stakeholders acquire, assess, process, and respond to SEL evidence as well as recognize that the development of their SEL knowledge is a highly contextualized process (Creswell, 2013; Guba & Lincoln, 1994). Further, a constructivist approach calls for the data collected to be rooted in the participants’ own words and experiences (Charmaz, 2014).

Sampling procedures, recruitment, and enrollment

Prospective participants were recruited using purposive sampling. The initial goal was to recruit at least 20 stakeholders, as this is the minimum required number of interviewees for grounded theory studies (Creswell, 2013). Purposive sampling was implemented by reaching out to organizations and entities in the field of SEL via email to help with recruitment. Prospective partners were presented with an overview of the study and a description of the required participant characteristics. Additional preliminary partnership outreach to assist with recruitment was conducted by a co-author while attending National SEL Week on Capitol Hill in Washington D.C. As a result, five SEL entities agreed to assist with recruitment. Partners received a research study flyer to distribute that contained a link to a Qualtrics form that provided a more detailed overview of the study and participant expectations as well as a short application to apply to be in the study. Following partnership outreach, participants were also recruited through existing networks on various social media platforms (e.g., LinkedIn).

Given that this study sought to recruit various stakeholders associated with SEL, applicants were subjected to broad inclusion criteria. Potential participants were notified via the application form that to participate in this study they did not have to be supportive of SEL in K-12 schools, did not need to have a specific stance on SEL, and could work or engage in environments that support or oppose SEL. Applicants had to reside in the United States and engage with SEL through one of the following roles: policymaker, policy advocate/analyst, parent/guardian of a K-12 student, K-12 practitioner (e.g., educator, SEL coach), school district personnel, school administrator (e.g., assistant principal), SEL researcher, or work in SEL program development. A total of 31 stakeholders applied during the open enrollment period, each meeting the study’s inclusion criteria. An additional stakeholder applied after enrollment was closed and was therefore deemed ineligible to participate. Each of the 31 applicants were sent an email inviting them to participate in the study and asking them to sign up for a focus group time slot. Six applicants either did not sign up for a focus group or did not attend their designated focus group. As a result, 25 stakeholders enrolled in and completed the study.

Participant characteristics

Participants ($n = 25$) spanned 13 states and Washington D.C. and included practitioners ($n = 7$), policy analysts and advocates ($n = 6$), school administrators at the district and school levels ($n = 5$), researchers ($n = 4$), and program developers ($n = 3$). Table 1 reports the sociodemographic characteristics, and Table 2 illustrates the employment characteristics of the sample. More than two thirds of participants identified as white and female, and slightly more than half of the sample worked in a school or school district setting. All but two participants noted that they work in or engage with environments that are supportive of SEL.

Table 1
Sociodemographic characteristics of participants.

Sociodemographic Variables	Stakeholders (n=25)
Gender identity, n (%)	
Female	22 (88.0)
Male	3 (12.0)
Mean Age (SD)	42.88 (10.40)
Median Age	45
Age Range (years)	28–64
Racial and Ethnic Identity, n (%)	
Asian or Asian American	1 (4.0)
Black, African, or African American	2 (8.0)
Hispanic or Latino/Latina/Latinx	1 (4.0)
Middle Eastern or North African	1 (4.0)
Multiracial	1 (4.0)
Jewish	1 (4.0)
White	17 (68.0)
I prefer not to say	1 (4.0)

Table 2
Employment characteristics of participants.

Employment Variables	Stakeholders (n = 25)
Stakeholder category, n (%)	
Practitioner ^a	7 (28.0)
Policy Advocate and/or Analyst	6 (24.0)
School Administrator (District or School Level)	5 (20.0)
Researcher	4 (16.0)
Program Developer	3 (12.0)
Employment Residency by State, n (%)	
California	4 (16.0)
Colorado	1 (4.0)
Connecticut	1 (4.0)
Delaware	2 (8.0)
Illinois	2 (8.0)
Indiana	1 (4.0)
Maryland	1 (4.0)
Massachusetts	1 (4.0)
Minnesota	1 (4.0)
New Jersey	1 (4.0)
New York	1 (4.0)
Oregon	1 (4.0)
Washington	7 (28.0)
Washington, D.C.	1 (4.0)
SEL Environment ^b , n (%)	
Supportive of SEL	23 (92.0)
Oppose SEL	1 (4.0)
No response	1 (4.0)

^a Practitioners consisted of K-12 educators (n = 5), a former SEL specialist and educator (n = 1), and an early childhood SEL coach (n = 1).

^b Participants were asked on their consent forms to describe the environment they either work or engage in, which also included their town/city and/or state of residency.

Data collection and coding procedures

Seven focus groups with SEL stakeholders (ranging from two to five participants) and two individual interviews were conducted. Systematic inquiries totaled 410 min of discussion using a semi-structured interview protocol approved by the university IRB. Interviews were centered around five topics of inquiry: how participants define SEL, the type of SEL evidence they use in their profession and for what purpose, how they find and access this evidence, and whether they experience challenges or barriers in finding and/or using evidence in their work. Interviews concluded by asking stakeholders what could help them address the challenges and barriers they face when using SEL evidence. Focus groups and interviews were conducted by three members of the research team.

Each transcript was double coded by two researchers and went through two cycles of coding using the qualitative software *Dedoose*. During first cycle coding, the objective was to identify the unique

experiences and ideas shared by each participant without binding the data to prefixed categories, ideas, or themes. In other words, through this coding process we let the data speak for itself. Three coding mechanisms were used during this cycle: initial, In vivo, and process coding techniques. Initial coding was used “to generate as many codes as possible...without considering possible relevance” (Emerson et al., 2011, p. 182; Saldana, 2016). Consistent with grounded theory research designs, initial coding was paired with In vivo coding to capture the “voice” and “worldviews” of the stakeholders, identify what was “significant” to each participant, and limit research bias (Charmaz, 2006, p. 57; Saldana, 2016, p. 106). Further, given that this study explored how stakeholders collect, use, and navigate the challenges related to SEL evidence and implementation, process coding was used as a method to capture the actions that stakeholders take in their respective professions (Saldana, 2016).

During second cycle coding, the objective was to categorize the first cycle codes to unearth patterns and emergent themes among the data. Focused coding was first conducted to identify the most frequently applied codes during first cycle coding to establish initial categories and subcategories from the data (Saldana, 2016). Following this process, axial coding techniques were used to refine and further develop these categories (Charmaz, 2014; Saldana, 2016). Finally, theoretical coding was used to help find “relationships between categories” to identify the most salient themes and patterns across participant responses (Charmaz, 2014, p. 63).

Results

This section explores themes related to how stakeholders define SEL, communicate SEL, access and use SEL evidence as well as the challenges and barriers stakeholders face when gathering and using evidence. Also presented are the needs that stakeholders identified to help address the challenges and barriers they face when accessing and using SEL evidence.

How SEL is defined

Stakeholders provided a range of answers when asked to define SEL, with no clear universal definition. Participants generally described SEL as a process that leads to long-term success. Some noted that SEL is contextual, shaped by individuals’ culture, background, location, and experiences. Others added that SEL includes both students and staff. Overall, stakeholders defined SEL as (1) developing skills, (2) a foundation for academic learning, (3) fostering humaneness, (4) challenging and ambiguous to others, and (5) having certain negative connotations.

SEL as skill development

When participants were asked what SEL means to them, nearly all of their responses included elements of intrapersonal or interpersonal skills. Of the 25 participants, 22 (88.0 %) referenced both interpersonal and intrapersonal skills, two (8.0 %) referenced only intrapersonal skills, and one (4.0 %) referenced neither. Participants described intrapersonal skills such as self-awareness, emotional regulation, executive functioning, and responsible decision-making, while interpersonal skills included relationship-building, communication, collaboration, and conflict resolution. Broad references were also made to the SEL competencies proposed by CASEL and to the SEL skills and mindsets identified by the Ecological Approaches to Social Emotional Learning (EASEL) Lab at Harvard University. Participants rarely made reference to emotions. Only two participants defined SEL as developing skills to regulate emotions. For example, Participant 9 mentioned “understanding how to regulate emotions,” and Participant 22 described teaching children “how to deal with really big feelings and emotions.” While there was strong agreement on the types of skills SEL involves, participants differed in how they believed these skills are best developed, with

some participants emphasizing direct instruction and others highlighting learning through social interactions and relationships. For instance, Participant 19 defined SEL as “a process of teaching” specific skills, while Participant 24 stated that SEL “happens through interactions and relationships, not so much through direct teaching.”

SEL as foundational for academic learning

Many participants referenced academic learning when defining SEL. Several asserted that SEL lays the groundwork for such learning. Participant 1 asserted that SEL is “the recipe for ensuring that students can actually learn the academics.” Participant 23 shared similar sentiments:

So for me, SEL means, I call it sometimes the base layer of education, I think it is the necessary connection, skills and mindsets and habits, we need to have to be successful in any endeavor, particularly in learning, if I don't have SEL alive and embedded in my classroom and really, you know, in the molecules... the oxygen that we breathe, I'm never going to get to teaching. So, for me, it's a necessary first step.

Participant 7 indicated that when SEL is implemented “effectively” students will emerge as “better human beings, and they'll be able to acquire their literacy and math content...and they'll be better thinkers.” They added that SEL is an “under tap[ped] resource” that can promote academic equity and reduce achievement gap across race and income levels, suggesting SEL supports the foundation for academic success in the classroom.

SEL as fostering humaneness

Several participants described SEL as fostering humanity, civic-mindedness, and peace around the world. Participant 2 clarified that SEL “recognizes the humaneness of people before learning can even begin” resulting in “getting to know people and how we collaborate together as humans before the work in education can occur.” Others noted that SEL helps students become “good” (Participant 5) and “better human beings” (Participant 7). Participant 12 defined SEL in relation to personal growth, “I'm always thinking about my students, but I'm always forgetting about how SEL has impacted my parenting as a mom and even as a wife... [SEL] has made me a better mom [and] has made me a better overall human being.” Others expounded on the impact of SEL on society. Participant 5, for example, described SEL as having three layers, with the first two involving the development of intrapersonal and interpersonal competencies and the third focusing on “how to be a good citizen in the world.” Likewise, Participant 10 described SEL as “understanding the world around you, yourself, and how to be not just a willing participant, but a quality participant.” Participant 14 perceived SEL as a tool for peacebuilding, “SEL for me is peace. I see it as a way to grow peace builders for tomorrow.” Participant 17 elaborated that SEL is a “process of developing the skills, the knowledge, the attitudes that are going to support that kind of, you know, safe environment for children and that peaceful world that we're all in aiming for.”

How SEL is being communicated

A theme that emerged from defining SEL was the identification of negative connotations associated with SEL, despite this not being a direct question posed to participants. Many identified “social and emotional learning” and its acronym “SEL” as the terms with the most negative connotations in SEL terminology. Participants 1 and 14 explained that SEL is “charged words” that “freaks people out.” Participant 11 added “families do not organically use the term social emotional learning,” while Participant 14 noted that SEL has “already compromised itself” resulting in “pushback.” Other SEL-related terms that have negative connotations included “whole child” (Participant 1), “restorative practices” (Participant 2), “emotional” (Participant 11), and

“values” (Participant 21). Participant 3 contended, “whatever language CASEL is using is not palatable.”

Stakeholders often face challenges in communicating SEL, as they must navigate how it is perceived by their intended audiences, sometimes adjusting their messaging to avoid resistance or controversy. Participant 21, for example, noted, “there's been direct connections that some [SEL] programs teach DEI [Diversity, Equity, and Inclusion]” while others may have connections to “CRT [Critical Race Theory] and gender identity.” Whether this is true or not, they added, “the idea that there could be that connection is been a big backlash, certain competencies are pushed back on more than others.” Notably, even talking about emotions is viewed negatively among some groups. Participant 11 stated, “the word ‘emotional’...carries a lot of like gender dynamics around it” which “turn[s] off certain groups of people”. They explained,

I think there are folks who no matter what kind of language you use, are really afraid of kids talking about emotions from a, you know, sometimes from a political perspective, sometimes from like, a deeply felt perspective that like this is going to make my kid weak to talk about their emotions in this way.

This suggests that, even when politics are not explicitly involved, there is still stigma and stereotypes that influence how individuals perceive emotions and approach emotion-based discourse.

In response to pushback around SEL, including from educators, participants identified alternative terms they found more effective when engaging in SEL-related discussions across settings where resistance may arise. Terms included the “brain” (Participant 14), “confidence” (Participant 11), “emotional intelligence,” “employability skills,” “character development,” “soft skills,” or “executive functioning” (Participant 25), and “life skills” (Participant 19). Although participants did not explore in detail the reasons for their reframing, some suggested that the terminology they use depends on their audience (e.g., using “good teaching practices” when talking about SEL with teachers), or aligns with what is promoted and/or accepted in the states they reside in (e.g., using “life skills” when talking about SEL). Participant 2, a school administrator, emphasized that reframing is a must when defining SEL, “[educators] will actually listen to me and not shut me down if I say those buzzwords.” While there is no universal definition of SEL, participants intentionally use specific terminology to encourage buy-in from those they work or engage with.

In addition to concerns about terminology, participants also noted the ongoing challenge of clearly defining what SEL means in practice. Participant 8 pointed out there is “backlash against SEL. So, what it is, what it isn't? There's a large divide in many of our states about what that looks like and sounds like and what it really is and is not.” Likewise, Participant 3 reflected that they are “continually painting the picture of what do we mean by SEL... What does this actually look like in practice...how does this play out in your child's literacy classroom...How does this play out in your schools' rituals and routines.” This suggests that some audiences lack a strong understanding of SEL, requiring some participants to continually define, explain, and communicate what SEL is.

How SEL evidence is accessed

Stakeholders looked to a range of individuals, organizations, and resources to access SEL evidence. Participants generally referred to (1) work of specific individuals, (2) information from specific organizations, (3) news from specific media outlets, (4) empirical studies within or beyond the SEL field, and (5) data collected in schools.

Following specific people

Stakeholders followed the work of several individuals within and beyond the SEL field. Individuals in higher education included Dr. Camille Farrington, Managing Director and Senior Research Associate at

the University of Chicago Consortium on School Research, Dr. Christina Cipriano, Director of the Education Collaboratory at the Yale Child Study Center, and Dr. Kristin Neff, an Associate Professor of Educational Psychology at the University of Texas (Austin). Individuals outside of higher education included Dr. Byron McClure, a school psychologist and founder of *Lessons for SEL*, and Mr. Simon Sinek, an author and inspirational speaker on leadership development. These individuals were viewed as credible and accessible sources, which highlights how expertise and the ability to clearly communicate research shape what stakeholders consider valid or useful SEL evidence.

Following specific organizations

For organizations, stakeholders most frequently referenced CASEL. Other research-based organizations included the American Institutes for Research (AIR), and the recently sunset Character Lab. Participants also identified higher education institutions, including the Education Collaboratory at Yale University and the EASEL laboratory at Harvard University. Participants further named national health or education organizations, like the American Academy of Pediatrics, the National Alliance on Mental Illness, the Robert Wood Johnson Foundation, Centers for Disease Control and Prevention, Department of Education, and What Works Clearinghouse. Educational organizations, like Panorama Education and Harmony Educational Services, were also mentioned.

Following specific media outlets

Stakeholders followed SEL content on media outlets. Some participants accessed specific educational media outlets for SEL evidence, such as Edutopia, Education Week, K-12 Dive, Chalkbeat, The 74, and the Hechinger Report. Several participants stated that they searched Google and Google Scholar for SEL evidence. Additionally, a few mentioned looking at SEL evidence on social media, like LinkedIn.

Drawing from empirical research

Stakeholders broadly referenced accessing SEL evidence from empirical research papers. Several suggested that they draw on evidence that is deemed scientifically rigorous, such as gathering “best practice” (Participant 1) and “evidence-based practices,” (Participant 9), recently published “important studies” (Participant 3), “strong research studies, longitudinal studies, pretest, posttest control group designs” (Participant 18), “all interventions associated [with] education... top level of evidence, randomized controlled trial, one level down quasi experimental... promising research” (Participant 20). The meta-analytic research that is widely referenced in the SEL field (e.g., [Cipriano et al., 2023](#); [Durlak et al., 2022](#)) was infrequently mentioned among participants ($n = 4$; 16.0 %).

Stakeholders also drew empirical research from specific areas within the SEL domain as well as across non-SEL fields and subject areas. Within the SEL field, participants actively sought out topics like transformative SEL, restorative practices, mindfulness, self-efficacy, and social awareness. Beyond the SEL field, participants looked at topics like technology, educational neuroscience, public psychology, implementation science, prevention science, and motivation theory. Stakeholders identified program development as the main reason for looking into topics beyond SEL. Participant 11 explained, “I work for a company that builds social emotional learning tools for kids...we try to work and take as broad based an approach is possible when looking at research that’ll inform our curriculum.” Similarly, Participant 17 noted, “it would be hard for me to kind of list all of the evidence that I’ve used building programs over the years...not just coming out of things specifically focused on social emotional learning, per se, but you know, going quite broad and out into other realms.” Responses suggest that stakeholders may use a multi-disciplinary approach to SEL program development.

Challenges with accessing empirical research

Stakeholders indicated that paywalls prevented access to SEL research. Participant 15 stated, “I don’t have a membership to a journal to get some information.” Participant 17 added, “you know, you need to be a graduate student to access the databases...if I ever lose that, I’ll probably, you know, fall down and cry...losing access to that will break my heart.” Additionally, participants noted the need for time to digest lengthy empirical research papers. Participant 4 explained, “most people here don’t have time to read a whole lot of...original source data.” Participant 23 echoed, “I think it’s hard...research article[s] tend to be very lengthy and very academic. So, as a busy teacher...sometimes I’m just really pressed for time. So, I want to access something that I can quickly go through and process in my brain.” They further added, “sometimes those scholarly articles are tough, even though I’m a smart person. And I’ve been in the field a long time, I wish there was almost like a bridge from a scholarly article to like a practice you can implement.”

Stakeholders highlighted the need for SEL research to be communicated in an accessible and meaningful manner for educators. Participant 25 indicated, “when people read things, they’re not going to read a whole article often and even myself sometimes.” They further called for SEL evidence to be communicated in “relatable,” “practical,” and “bite sized” ways. Participant 19 added, “I would love to see more of that translation of... practical implications. What does this mean? ... Should schools avoid doing this type of implementation? I know that... goes against the grain, you know, recommendations that researchers want to make.” Stakeholders wished for a “one stop shop” (Participant 12) that provides evidence-based, developmentally appropriate, and culturally responsive SEL practices for diverse groups of students in specific contexts (e.g., math, ELA).

Drawing from school data

Stakeholders also drew SEL evidence from data collected in schools, specifically SEL assessments like the Devereux Student Strengths Assessment (DESSA), the YouthTruth survey, and school climate surveys. Participants also indicated metrics of key performance indicators as SEL evidence, including disciplinary data, academic achievement data, attendance data, classroom observations, and student evaluations. Several noted the importance of personal accounts or anecdotal evidence. Participant 8 posited that SEL “can’t be measured by a test score...And so, it can’t be a number...So a lot of our districts are leaning towards that street data and empathy interviews to gather evidence.” Participant 5 echoed:

when we talk to the kids and the teachers, the quotes that we get from them are so great and so inspiring. Like, all these stories of kids saying, I didn’t think I belong here, I didn’t think I didn’t know about STEM, I didn’t feel like I should be in this class. Like, I’ve never been good at math, you know, all of that thing. And then I got here, and now I want to be a doctor. I mean, it’s just really, really amazing stories.

Additionally, Participant 23 stressed that “[SEL] evidence” can be both “scholarly...research” and exist naturally in “the human space.” They explained,

I think SEL evidence is something that you would spy with your little eye when you walk into a room. So, if you walk into my third-grade classroom, you’re gonna see kids moving, kids talking, kids connecting, you’re gonna see routines in place, you’re gonna see safety, you’re gonna see people helping each other.

Challenges with accessing school data

Stakeholders highlighted difficulties collecting and working with

SEL data from schools. Participant 7 indicated that districts are not investing enough in SEL to collect adequate data to demonstrate the impact of SEL in schools:

Anytime you implement something that leads to change, you're literally having to fight off all the people who are saying that they don't want to do it. And you've got to fight them off for three to five years, long enough for the industry to get an outcome.

Participant 8 elaborated that districts' competing priorities and lack of commitment to SEL initiatives lead them to move onto the "next shiny object" after a year rather than allowing "3–5 years for something to take flight." Participant 25 added that districts adopt a remediation approach where there is "more of a priority on mental health in school counselors and school social workers in schools" rather than a preventative approach with "proactive SEL strategies that are good for all educators and good for all kids." Another issue brought up by participants was confidentiality of SEL data. Participant 19 explained, "something that happened in relation to the politicization of SEL, there has been ... a trend around protecting student data privacy and ensuring that parent consent for certain student data." As the SEL field becomes more politicized, it may be harder for schools to collect SEL data.

Once data is collected, participants mentioned various challenges they face when working with SEL data, such as challenges with analyzing and interpreting data, resolving discrepancies across data types and sources (e.g., qualitative data showing SEL as having a positive impact while quantitative data yields no significant improvements across outcomes; lack of teacher student congruence), and generating data-informed action steps.

How SEL evidence is used

Stakeholders primarily used SEL evidence to (1) promote buy-in for SEL and (2) shape teaching and learning, both of which are explored in greater detail below. Participants also used SEL evidence to develop SEL programming, examine SEL efficacy, support educational decision-making, and inform educational policy and advocacy.

Using SEL evidence to influence SEL buy-in

Stakeholders used SEL evidence to facilitate buy-in from teachers. Participant 2, for example, used SEL evidence to demonstrate the utility of SEL to teachers, noting that, "I always make sure I try to connect to existing research so that they see the value [of] what I'm trying to tell them." Participant 4 used SEL evidence to address current concerns or needs of teachers: "they want to hear about how it supports students having more capacity to absorb information. So...self-management is a big thing in talking to some of our teachers, so if we say that this will help with that particular whatever the problem that they think is foremost in their mind."

Stakeholders also used SEL evidence to connect SEL with priorities and goals for schools and districts. For instance, Participant 7 used SEL evidence to show that SEL is worth the investment:

I use it [SEL evidence] to make a determination of purchasing something, you know, making choices, right? When you're, obviously we've all experienced when you're doing budgets, and you're having to bring in something new, right...you have to make a decision to not do something else. So, the evidence becomes really important, when you're trying to make a claim that you're going to make a difference in the life [of a] student with...the purchase of something.

Similarly, Participant 4 used SEL evidence "to give people the big picture and the local picture" of the importance of SEL in education and their school:

even if there are multiple studies...that mirror our demographics, our district doesn't buy it, like not for a second unless it's their own kids. So, I usually start with the bigger frames...But then we have to do our own internal analyses and say, see, there are some interesting things to look at here with regard to attendance or with regard to the connections with, I won't say correlations, but connections with test scores, because our administrator team is very, of course, interested in the state test scores, and what can be done to move up ELA and math scores. So, I have to frame things using that perspective as well.

Notably, anecdotal evidence, like success stories of SEL, emerged as a powerful tool to enhance buy-in among educators. Participant 1 explicated that:

The schools we see the most success with are the leaders that are prioritizing SEL. And so, we'll oftentimes kind of like raise them up and help them be the ones to tell the story. Because educators are more apt to listen to educators, district leaders are more apt to listen and district leaders.

Using SEL evidence to shape teaching and learning

Stakeholders used SEL evidence to inform teaching and learning. Participant 1 spoke of "utilizing what's best practice out in the field" to "shap[e]...new activities or curriculum." Likewise, Participant 11 reported that "every piece of content we make sort of starts with a research brief and then gets turned into something for kids." Participant 6 noted using DESSA data from schools "to determine which strategies we should embed into classes." Participant 10 provided insight into how SEL evidence is used to create a classroom environment that is optimal for teaching and learning,

A lot of the work that I'm doing is in the counseling department, and so at a K through eight, and so I'll hear from a teacher, like on a day, this is what my sixth graders are dealing with. They're having a rough time with this week. Can we touch on this in class? So even though I've got a curriculum I'm working through, I do a lot of like, stop and go with that. And a lot of like, okay, wait, this is what we're dealing with, like, Let's go research this, let's go find some tools for today.

Participant 23 added that "we're starting math, 10 min late, because we're journaling this morning" because "I saw like four kids walk in having a very rough time." They explained that their students "take the time to journal" because this allows them to "pivot to math and have a great math lesson rather than going right into the math lesson and having it not work at all, because a bunch of kids are really unbalanced."

Using SEL evidence: challenges and barriers

When asked about the challenges and barriers that stakeholders face when using evidence in their professions, many participants responded by referencing the general challenges and barriers they face when trying to implement SEL. Thus, findings related to the challenges and barriers of using SEL evidence and SEL implementation are presented in this section together.

Difficult using evidence in practice. Findings suggest that SEL research may not be trickling down to the classroom levels in ways that researchers and policymakers may anticipate. Stakeholders frequently referenced factors associated with teachers and teaching that make it difficult to implement SEL. For example, participants identified turnover and burnout in addition to feeling overwhelmed and overburdened by their non-SEL responsibilities as barriers toward SEL implementation. Participant 6 explained, "we are trying to also be very thoughtful of how we and what resources we're using, because I feel like if we try to do too much, we're gonna have burnout on the teachers end of it, and then we won't be implementing anything with fidelity." In this situation, the way

in which evidence can be used is contingent on the number of responsibilities an educator may have. Other stakeholders directly referenced teacher opposition, citing veteran staff, teachers arguing that SEL is not part of their job responsibilities, and the need to focus on academics. Participant 25 noted that some educators may feel “we don’t have enough time, or we’re a failing school already. And so, we need to focus on academics.” Similarly, Participant 2 shared that she may ask a homeroom teacher, “Let’s check in how are they doing just doing a wellness check?” She explained that this may result in a teacher pushing back, stating, “Nope, not on my contract...there’s so much my contract says that I need to get through this many minutes of academic instruction...you are just putting more and more on my plate that is not in my contract.” Participants also noted several other barriers, such as teachers lacking implementation supports, SEL not being embedded in teacher preparation time, a lack of SEL knowledge, and limited time to implement an SEL curriculum. Participant 23, for example, reflected, “I try and stay away from packaged curriculum, because I think it’s not as organic as SEL should be” and “as a classroom teacher, I don’t have time to...take a package lesson and build it in, I just need to build in the competencies and the practices within what we’re doing.”

Misinformation and misconceptions. Challenges to using evidence also exist outside of the classroom. Although not frequently mentioned among interview responses, stakeholders highlighted the difficulty in presenting SEL to individuals who have developed misguided perceptions of the field. Participant 2 summed up this struggle with parents, stating, “Facebook is the death of us. And what parents will form is their narratives of social emotional learning” motivating them to “come in the office fired up asking, you’re supposed to teach the standards and the academics, why are you making our kids talk that so then you have the parent perspective of that, too.” Participant 4 echoed a similar experience, explaining that parents are “afraid” that SEL is “therapy” and “that we’re going to get inside the heads of their children and...what’s happening in their homes. And it’s very invasive.” Thus, the misperception that SEL cannot or is not related to academics and is instead intrusive into the personal lives of families can result in parent pushback against SEL.

News articles reporting on SEL evidence may also miscommunicate findings. For example, Participant 4 explained that news articles that report on critiques of SEL evidence can be used against the field, even if the article also talks about the field’s strengths. She recalled a time when her district made a decision on SEL because of what an SEL researcher wrote in an op-ed. Participant 4 explained that this author argued that

SEL is racism with a hug...And instead of reading the whole article, that one sentence was used by our district to say...because we found this sentence, we’re not going to do SEL anymore. So, it almost completely derailed...several years of work, because they in the way the article was laid out, that quote, was in a big box. And that’s what they took as the meaning of the whole article.

Consequently, the school district used SEL evidence that was not grounded in data but rather the opinion of the author. Recalling a similar experience, Participant 21 described an interaction with a lawmaker,

We ran into that recently with a lawmaker whose kid gotten brought home it SEL worksheet, and now she’s not a big fan, she wants something really intensive to address the problems. And but we don’t know what that is, right? We have no clue if that’s a one sheet from a program something they’re just calling SEL, because she saw it and went, This isn’t going to address the youth mental health crisis. And we’re trying to figure out what even is that is SEL.

In this situation, the lawmaker likely formed an opinion based on lesson that would not be considered evidenced-based SEL. Regardless, participant testimony indicates that misinformation and misconceptions of what SEL is has far-reaching consequences that can influence how parents, school districts, and lawmakers perceive and support SEL.

Stakeholder needs to address current challenges and barriers

At the end of each focus group and/or interview, participants were asked what would help them address the challenges and barriers they face. Regarding research, participants frequently requested more qualitative evidence, such as observational data and district, teacher, and parental success stories related to SEL. Additionally, data pertaining to student perceptions and feelings is also needed. Participant 4 summed up the need for qualitative evidence, arguing,

the quantitative data, or the research is only as strong as the stories that we front loaded with. So, if we tell the story of this kid or this teacher, and then we are able to say and look, this not war...what we need is, maybe if there...little like, vignettes, or something of where...it’s going really well, or what this sort of voices of students or teachers or parents telling their stories, and then backing that up with...what the broader research shows.

Similarly, Participant 22 noted that this type of evidence is “helpful to policymakers.” She referenced an event where a six-year-old girl spoke out against an anti-SEL bill in front of New Hampshire lawmakers by sharing how SEL has positively impacted her.

Stakeholders called for quantitative data to be paired with qualitative examples. For instance, Participant 3 explained, “I think the sort of data plus story is a key piece for me. So, let’s tell the numbers, and then let’s pair it with voices and stories of real people.” Participant 3 further accentuated, “From a district point of view. I will say, I think there’s a qualitative side as well...I think that type of storytelling can be really powerful for district leaders and school leaders.” Likewise, Participant 20 stressed that “districts.... look at cases, and that’s what persuades them. So, you can talk about the heavy evidence. But if you don’t give an example, you probably won’t get as much traction as you otherwise would.” Moreover, participant testimony indicates that qualitative evidence can give a voice to quantitative data, allowing evidence to be communicated in a more meaningful and engaging way.

Additionally, participants specified areas of research where they would like more evidence from. Participant 23 suggested that for the field to better understand the challenges that teachers face it is necessary to ask them directly. Participant 11, on the other hand, suggested that it’s probable that families “use really different language to describe the kinds of things that we’re trying to teach” and as a result, the field needs to explore how families talk about emotions naturally in the household. Another need was an analysis of studies that report unfavorable outcomes. Participant 21 explained, we’re interested both in just transparency and accountability way, but also...sometimes these studies will go around and around and spawn a lot of as [] positive ones do too. So, I don’t want to knock it, but you know, a study that has poor results will get, you know, sent around, and we have to figure out as not research experts, if, you know, that’s how valid that study is.

In essence, Participant 21 suggests that future research should consider exploring the validity and methodology of studies that do not find positive SEL outcomes.

Stakeholders also referenced the importance and need for context-driven evidence and research. For example, Participant 21 explained that she receives requests from stakeholders for specific information and stressed the “need” for “any sort of customization” of data like “urban versus rural” and “state specific.” Likewise, Participant 20 argued, “you know, a small district in Wisconsin doesn’t care what L.A. does, they feel like they are worlds apart. But if I find when it’s similarly matched, demographically size wise, by other interesting features they care about, I think that would be really helpful.” Thus, participant responses suggest that without context, generalized data is meaningless to SEL decision-makers who are looking for more nuanced information. Further, Participant 21 also noted that it is important for research to explore relationships between SEL and a wide range of outcomes related to students and schools. She underscored the fact that “stakeholders...see their situation as unique” so it’s necessary to provide them data that fits their unique needs. Having contextual data as it relates to students is

also needed. Participant 25, for instance, called for more evidence that demonstrates how SEL impacts “marginalized groups.” In addition, other participants noted the need to link SEL to student outcomes. This included calling for additional research on how SEL impacts academics (test scores, grades), mental health, changes in aggressive behavior, as well as general youth development issues. Stakeholders also called for research exploring how SEL can be integrated into current curriculum and within specific subject matters.

Participant 18 also spoke about the importance of reporting results in ways that are relevant and useful to schools. For instance, she highlighted the fact that some programs that the research literature reports on may not be available to schools outside of the research context. She stressed, “schools want to identify programs that will work for them.” Participant 18 also argued that along with information on whether a program is available, there needs to be clear data on the context in which the program is being evaluated in. She explained, “I can imagine a lot of the southern states that we would work with...would say, Yeah, but has it been evaluated...with our kind of population.” In essence, SEL evidence needs to be conducted and reported in contextual ways for states and schools to better connect with potential SEL programming.

The way in which evidence is reported on and disseminated is another area that stakeholders want improved. One request was to disseminate evidence using non-SEL organizations. Participant 1 argued that there is a need for “a more unifying entity.” She further explained, “I don’t think SEL is divisive, but I think in this climate, it can be seen as such and so finding spaces homes for this like type of information to live that...doesn’t [] make people think a certain way when they go to it.” Essentially, Participant 1 suggests that SEL-focused websites come across as biased in favor of SEL. Other participants highlighted the need to share evidence via venues that are accessible to all and not placed behind paywalls. Two participants also accentuated the importance of brevity when communicating evidence. One participant specifically suggested conveying evidence through social media carousels and newsletters.

Additionally, there was a desire among some stakeholders to bridge the research and practice spaces. Suggestions included having opportunities for non-researchers to speak and engage with researchers through conferences, symposiums, and workshops, incorporating practitioners in the research space and establishing a consortium of district and state leaders and/or a consortium of educators. Several stakeholders also spoke about the importance of engaging with parents, so they are better informed about SEL. Participant 11 stressed that “we know that there are a lot of families and kids that value empathy and responsibility and those other things for their kids. And yet, a lot of them probably use really different language to describe the kinds of things that we’re trying to teach.” Additionally, Participant 2 explained that her school district has seen success by providing opportunities for parents to have “biweekly coffee with the principal.”

Stakeholders also identified a number of needs to better support SEL implementation at the school and classroom levels. Responses indicated that SEL is entering a post-pandemic uncertainty with budget cuts to K-12 education and a refocus on academics due to learning loss. Stakeholders identified more funding, additional SEL specialist positions, teacher thought partners, and SEL professional development opportunities for school leadership. Stakeholders also stressed the importance of and need for adult SEL in the teaching space.

Discussion

At the time we prepared this manuscript for review, the nation was witnessing an ongoing youth mental health crisis, a transition in power at the federal level, a renewed energy to reshape public K-12 education, and an SEL field that is expanding while under a political microscope. In this study, we provide preliminary evidence of the challenges to SEL stakeholders’ access and use of SEL research evidence across the education ecosystem in the current socio-political context. With the

intention of supporting stakeholders to navigate SEL evidence in a polarized socio-political climate, we conclude with a discussion of opportunities to advance SEL evidence access and use across the education ecosystem. Although this study provided rich data on ways in which stakeholders access and use evidence-based SEL as well as the barriers they face, testimony indicated that challenges exist beyond accessing SEL evidence. Findings from this study yielded significant implications for communicating research and practice across the SEL field and challenges the existing notions and structures that the SEL field currently operates on. We address these tensions and opportunities in turn.

SEL evidence does not speak for itself

Findings suggest that both SEL programs and their respective and collective evidence of effectiveness (1) lack accessibility for policy makers, educational leaders, and practitioners and (2) the evidence that is available is limited in its translation to use in practice. Due to paywalls, subscriptions, and membership fees, confounded by the academic jargon and analytic speak of empirical research articles, participants noted that they must rely on public communications of evidence through free or practitioner focused channels of dissemination. Despite the abundance of research evidence demonstrating the benefits of SEL for the social, emotional, and academic growth of students, research is not being translated to educators in meaningful and helpful ways. This disconnect does not suggest that educators are opposed to SEL evidence but rather highlights the need for more practical research that offers integrative strategies that better align with their demanding schedules and workloads. Although stakeholders were clear that quantitative research is important to their messaging and rationale for the use of SEL in schools, participants also spoke about the importance and need for qualitative and anecdotal evidence, arguing that this helps humanize quantitative information.

Our pilot work points to a need to (1) communicate research evidence across broader dissemination channels that are accessible to stakeholders and to (2) increase the specificity of what is communicated so that it can be used by stakeholders to inform decision making across their respective levels of the ecosystem. Interview responses suggest that in some cases, the types of evidence gathered are influenced by the challenges and barriers that stakeholders have when accessing certain types of information. Most stakeholders only access SEL evidence that is publicly available in *front* of paywalls, subscriptions, and memberships. Leaving meaning making to what is conveyed to the public leaves a tremendous amount to chance. Who decides which findings are held up in the news and education media? Are they communicated in ways that are accessible and hold utility for educators or those who stand to benefit from them? Are they written in ways that are true to the evidence that they may be drawing from that exists *behind* the paywalls? Rather than leave research to be interpreted and conveyed by external sources, researchers must communicate their findings directly to the stakeholders their work is intended for.

Participants noted that in particular, interpreting how SEL could be implemented in practice is often left to chance. Across evidence types, participants noted a lack of communication about what the evidence looks like in practice beyond the generalizations that it is or is not effective. For example, it is well documented that teachers have limited time and resources to prep and support their classroom functioning at large (Braga et al., 2024; Lin et al., 2024), and our participants noted that there is no time to interpret SEL evidence and think through how it can be incorporated into curricula. While knowing that SEL is effective is helpful for a school board meeting, this understanding does not translate into what an educator should do to implement SEL effectively in the classroom. Across multiple focus groups, stakeholders repeatedly requested that SEL evidence be more contextualized and specific. For example, are SEL programs implemented in urban schools effective in rural communities? What are the differences between SEL programs and

how can we know which one is better for our school needs or district priorities? Indeed, all SEL stakeholders have the potential to use evidence differently, as schools, districts, teachers, and lawmakers have their own needs, agendas, and understandings of what SEL entails and how they may choose to use the evidence, whether in support of or against it. With this leeway, it is possible that current SEL evidence may be unintentionally misinterpreted by stakeholders. This is an area that warrants further investigation.

Open to interpretation

The varied, diverse, and in some cases, contradictory ways in which stakeholders spoke about SEL evidence confirmed that there is a lack of alignment within the research, practice, and policy arenas as to what is SEL and what counts as SEL evidence. Although the amorphous definition of what constitutes SEL has been a topic of discourse and debate for the better part of the past three decades (see [Elias & Yuan, 2020](#)), a prominent finding that emerged through this research is that the heterogeneity in what is considered SEL is also a contributing factor to the misinformation of SEL in the current socio-political climate.

SEL stakeholders who consider SEL explicit skill instruction (sometimes referred to as “traditional” SEL, [Lim et al., 2024](#)), are very quick to comment on and confirm that SEL is not a trojan horse for CRT. SEL stakeholders who consider SEL justice-focused (sometimes referred to as “transformative;” see [Jagers et al., 2019](#)), speak about how SEL could or should include elements of critical social justice or liberatory pedagogy. Although not explicitly CRT, and most certainly not indoctrination, this framing of SEL can be misconstrued as such and used to fuel disinformation about SEL when left open to interpretation. Although the most recent meta-analysis of SEL cataloged more than 4000 skills and strategies included in SEL programs, authors found no evidence of anti-racism nor patriotism in programs, respectively ([Cipriano et al., 2023](#)).

When SEL could be everything, it leaves open to interpretation that SEL is nothing. And when it is being marketed as everything, it is difficult at best and impossible at worst to communicate about in ways that foster unilateral buy-in. Consider, how SEL is marketed to states impacts how it is positioned in state level standards and accountability systems. How SEL is marketed impacts how districts make decisions about program adoption and where SEL fits into strategic initiatives. How SEL is communicated about from the district to the school affects how the school buys into the implementation of SEL. Is SEL positioned as another thing or a foundational aspect of the school day? Is SEL something that is nice to have but not necessary if time needs to be spent more on other priorities? Is SEL only for some students, some grades, and some classrooms? Inevitably, this buy-in varies by teacher and shows up in how they choose to implement SEL in their classrooms. And this buy-in trickles to the students, who may or may not decide that this is something worth their energy, time, or attention, based on how their teacher has positioned SEL. All SEL stakeholders stand to benefit from explicit and consistent communications about SEL evidence that are meaningful to their respective contexts, needs, and interests.

The role of media communications

Our study confirmed that most people do not read academic articles in pursuit of evidence ([Eveleth, 2014](#)), and that rather most consume their information through education news media by way of social channels (such as X, Instagram, Facebook, TikTok, and podcasts) and direct electronic communications from organized educational media, agencies, news outlets and centers ([Pew Research Center, 2024](#)). The education media’s role in informing the public about SEL evidence underscored our study findings.

It is no secret that the news media, including education media, often carry political biases ([Ad Fontes Media, 2025](#)). Case in point, at the time we were preparing this article, the national news media was nearing an inflection point, with fallout from major news outlets in response to

reporting and failures to provide endorsements surrounding the most recent presidential election (see Los Angeles Times and the Washington Post).

And when it comes to SEL evidence, the news media has shown its potential to be biased. For example, at the same time Edutopia named the most recent meta-analysis of SEL effectiveness one of the top studies in education of 2023 ([Terada & Merrill, 2023](#)), the Hechinger Report reported, “Schools spend millions on programs despite little hard evidence to show what works” ([Barshay, 2023, n.p.](#)). This conclusion, based on the testimony from a conservative-based think tank research fellow, offered no evidence to substantiate such a claim, despite the meta-analytic study under question employing best practices of open science and research synthesis and demonstrating robust evidence of effectiveness ([Barshay, 2023](#)).

Similarly, a report sponsored by the Hoover Institution reviewed four decades of evidence of trends in public education and suggested that findings from systematic reviews and meta-analyses of SEL do “not meet the US Department of Education standards for strong or moderate evidence” ([Bowen & Raymond, 2023, p. 53](#)). The evidence used to back this statement cited the lack of strong effects related to academic outcomes from **one research study** conducted by Rand Corporation ultimately overlooking the entire body of reviews amassed to date ([Cipriano et al., 2023; Durlak et al., 2022; Greenberg, 2023](#)).

The way in which media outlets and organizations interpret and select to report on SEL evidence has the power to shape SEL policy and practice. The original “A Nation at Risk” report influenced thousands of educational reforms within six years of being published, affecting students and teachers across the United States ([Bowen & Raymond, 2023, p. 1](#)). The report also had significant influence on the Reagan Administration’s view of the role of the Department of Education ([Hess, 2023](#)). With SEL filtering into political discourse and policy, and a new presidential administration that has signaled its interest in reshaping the U.S. education system ([Burke, 2023](#)), media articles and reports that communicate SEL evidence in ways that undermine, misinterpret, or misuse findings run the risk of fueling educational reforms that adversely impact research and implementation at the federal and state levels.

Policy with a big and a little P

Policy with a capital or ‘big’ p refers to the legislation and policy as written in any given governing document, whereas policy with a lowercase or ‘little’ p refers to the norms and practice of how a policy plays out in practice. Our study illuminated that stakeholders’ experiences of SEL have remained largely consistent, despite the flux of state-level policies. That consistency, however, was specific to each stakeholder and their respective schools, organizations, and states. What they did or didn’t do did not change as a function of policy with a big P, just merely how they talked about it.

Good policy reflects what is happening on the ground to promote the proliferation of evidence-based practices in schools, and resources that enable conditions therewithin to make this evidence-based practice a reality. We suggest the following recommendations for the SEL field:

Recalibrating SEL research. We documented a significant gap in SEL research: how to measure and support what is happening on the ground in real time. Participants suggested that current education practices and experiences do not inform current SEL research. The SEL field can better understand (a) whether and how teachers are incorporating SEL naturally across the school day and within specific subject matter, and (b) where school district leaders and staff are gathering SEL evidence, (b1) how they are interpreting this evidence and (b2) whether and how these interpretations are informing practice. For instance, several stakeholders wished for SEL to be integrated into specific subjects, grades, or pre-existing curriculum, rather than being stand alone. Low time and low-cost SEL strategy instruction that supports teachers with their SEL instructional needs throughout a school day, such as the

Kernels approach to SEL (Jones et al., 2017), is likely a feasible choice for schools nationwide in light of the current socio-political climate around SEL. Stakeholders would benefit from additional empirical research that supports, validates, and extends low-cost models such as these.

Reconnect with stakeholders. Whether the narrative is based on fact or not, the messaging against SEL is consistent, effective, and rooted in accessible language that appeals to a wide audience. Although SEL science is not politically partisan, the Democratic Party's messaging across the 2024 election season can serve as a learning opportunity for the SEL field. Like the voting electorate, SEL stakeholders are more likely to pay attention to evidence from people and places that we have decided that we trust. And right now, based on how stakeholders across this sample are referring to evidence, everyone has the opportunity to be a producer and a consumer of evidence, whether or not the evidence is based in research. This reality is increasing the gap between SEL researchers, practitioners, and decision-makers. A better understanding of the mechanisms through which stakeholders perceive and interact with SEL evidence, especially among district and school leaders, educators, parents, local politicians, and school board members by researchers can reduce this gap. Both the SEL research and policy ecosystems will benefit from different groups of people understanding, talking about, and engaging with social and emotional topics and terminologies. And most importantly, the field must better identify and find ways to address the needs across stakeholder groups, with specific attention to parents and educators. By doing so, the field can better learn how to connect with those who stand to benefit from and/or are responsible for SEL implementation. This reconnection is essential to the growth and sustainability of this field, to improve buy-in, and control the narrative around SEL in K-12 classrooms.

One such example of this reconnection with key stakeholders that deserves attention from the field is occurring in California, where teachers are engaging in discussions and initiatives centered on adult SEL. Duane et al. (2025) examined a 12-week, graduate-level continuing education course at UC Berkeley, offered free of charge to educators through funding from the California Department of Health Care Services via the CalHOPE initiative, that enrolled teachers from 120 school districts and was designed to strengthen in-service teachers' capacities for implementing SEL. The curriculum sought to help teachers build an understanding of systemic SEL, consider how adult SEL supports student outcomes, examine the relationship between SEL and educational equity, and apply research to real-world planning and implementation. The study found increases in educators' self-reported attitudes toward SEL, self-efficacy, and perceived support as well as large effects on SEL skills and knowledge. Improvements in well-being were also found, measured in part by reductions in teacher burnout. In our pilot study, both teacher burnout and a lack of understanding of what SEL entails emerged as key barriers to implementation. Duane et al. (2025) findings suggest that reconnecting with educators through well-designed adult SEL initiatives may help address both challenges, ultimately supporting stronger engagement, trust, and buy-in for SEL in schools and classrooms.

Limitations and implications for future research

Several limitations emerged across this study. First, the sample size is small, and as a result, the findings should be considered preliminary and not assumed to be generalizable. Findings warrant a quantitative study that surveys stakeholders across types and represents all 50 states. Although there was rich data pertaining to teachers, much of this information was provided by non-classroom practitioners. Additional research is needed from teachers directly as this will provide a refined educator perspective as to why teachers may oppose SEL and/or struggle to implement SEL in their classrooms. Nearly all participants stated that they either worked and/or engaged in environments that support SEL. The ways in which stakeholders collect SEL evidence, the challenges

they face using such evidence, and their needs to address these challenges, are likely different in less SEL-friendly environments. Relatedly, due to IRB restrictions, we were not able to collect political affiliation data explicitly in our study. Future research should therefore explore whether and how stakeholders that work in or engage in environments that do not support SEL gather and use evidence.

Parent data was also missing from this study. Despite recruitment being open to parents, no parents enrolled. This is likely due to the partnerships we used to recruit. Parents are increasingly playing a key role in advocating for and against SEL in schools. Public opinion polling has shown that parents generally have positive views of SEL (McGraw Hill, 2021; National Parent Teacher Association, 2022). Support, however, can be influenced by several factors. Research and public opinion polling, for instance, has shown that parent support can be influenced by the terminology used (life skills vs. social and emotional learning), political affiliation, and the grade level of their children (Horowitz, 2022; Tyner, 2021). In addition, parents are also being given more legal authority to intervene in their children's education. Political organizations, for example, are pushing for increase parent involvement in education (e.g., America First Policy Institute), and several states, like Arizona (Arizona Department of Education, 2023), Georgia (Georgia House Bill, 1178, 2022), and Florida (Florida House Bill 241, 2021) have codified parent's rights to be more involved in their children's schooling. The absence of parent data in this study limits our understanding of the broader family context surrounding SEL, including how parental and familial attitudes, beliefs, and culture may shape or reflect the implementation of SEL in schools (Cipriano & McCarthy, 2023). As parents and families continue to play a key role in promoting or hindering SEL in classrooms, it is necessary to better understand and explore whether and how their knowledge of SEL research is being mobilized, communicated, and used. Future studies should therefore use more targeted recruitment efforts to enroll parents, such as partnering with local school boards as well as district and school administrators that are both for and against the implementation of SEL in schools.

The use of focus groups also presented limitations to data collection. During focus group sessions, one or more participants can naturally emerge as leaders of the group which can dominate the direction of the conversation as well as speaking time. Although we strived to conduct focus groups with individuals from the same stakeholder group (e.g., only educators), due to scheduling conflicts, some focus groups comprised of multiple stakeholder types (e.g., educators with SEL researchers), which may have made it difficult for some participants to engage in more detailed conversations about their experiences with others they could not relate to. To capture specific and more nuanced information pertaining to specific stakeholder experiences, future research should explore SEL evidence using classroom observations, one-on-one interviews with each stakeholder type, and anonymous surveys that use both closed and open-ended responses. To gain a more nuanced insight into how specific stakeholder groups are accessing and using evidence, future research should also consider implementing studies that focus on only a single stakeholder type.

Further, there were also differences in stakeholder experiences, which led to several discrepancies and tensions within the data. For example, our findings indicate that program developers draw on broad research evidence, including from outside the SEL field, whereas school-level decision-makers tend to view such broad evidence as less useful. Instead, they express a need for more context-specific and locally relevant data to support implementation and educator/administrator buy-in. Although our initial aim was to compare perspectives and experiences across stakeholders (e.g., educators, researchers, policy advocates), the variation in focus group composition inhibited cross-group comparisons. Recruiting a larger and more diverse sample and/or using national surveys exploring how SEL evidence is accessed, understood, and used would ultimately allow for comparisons between stakeholder groups as well as among subgroups within a single stakeholder type (e.g., teachers in a pro-SEL state vs teachers in an anti-SEL state). This

would ultimately support more targeted and actionable recommendations for improving SEL evidence use that reflect the range of stakeholder needs. Finally, although participants did speak about their successes when accessing and using SEL evidence, this study focused predominately on the challenges they faced. Learning more from stakeholder successes when interacting with SEL evidence is equally important in shaping SEL research, policy, practice, and messaging and therefore should be prioritized in future studies.

Conclusion

This pilot study documented how SEL stakeholders understand, access, and use SEL evidence in the current socio-political climate. Findings suggest that SEL research evidence is currently operating at a bird's-eye view, while stakeholder testimony suggests the need for researchers and policymakers to take a more granular and context-driven approach to applying SEL evidence to messaging, policy, and practice in more accessible and relevant ways. Evolving opportunities for stakeholders to access and have the opportunity to use and benefit from SEL evidence is a critical area for growth in this current socio-political climate.

CRediT authorship contribution statement

Cheyeon Ha: Writing – review & editing, Writing – original draft. **Christina Cipriano:** Writing – review & editing, Writing – original draft, Project administration, Methodology, Investigation, Funding acquisition, Formal analysis, Data curation, Conceptualization. **McCarthy Michael Frank:** Writing – review & editing, Writing – original draft, Project administration, Methodology, Investigation, Formal analysis, Data curation, Conceptualization. **Ahmad Eliya:** Writing – review & editing, Writing – original draft, Project administration, Methodology, Investigation, Formal analysis, Data curation, Conceptualization. **Barnes Sophie P:** Writing – review & editing, Writing – original draft. **Zi Jia Ng:** Writing – review & editing, Writing – original draft.

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The authors declare the following financial interests/personal relationships which may be considered as potential competing interests: Dr. Christina Cipriano reports financial support was provided by Institute of Education Sciences. Two of the co-authors on this manuscript submission are on the journal's editorial board. If there are other authors, they declare that they have no known competing financial interests or personal relationships that could have appeared to influence the work reported in this paper.

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